ETHICS & AI / TOPIC 3

AI, misinformation and democracy

Deepfakes, false identities and platform responsibility

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TERMINOLOGY

Key concepts

MISINFORMATION

False information shared without a deliberate intention to mislead.

DISINFORMATION

False or misleading information deliberately spread to deceive.

DEEPFAKES AND IMPERSONATION

Synthetic audio, images or video that imitate a real person or event.

FABRICATED NEWS AND ALGORITHMS

AI can produce false news stories. Recommender systems select and rank what users see.

The same false post can begin as disinformation and spread further as misinformation.

[2] Council of Europe / Wardle & Derakhshan. [10] European Commission. Algorithm descriptions are our own.

Figure 4.1: the ripple effects of technology

INDIVIDUAL

What rights and duties do citizens, impersonated people and those sharing content have?

SOCIETAL

How does technology affect shared trust, public debate and political participation?

POLITICAL AND POLICY

Who should set the rules, supervise compliance and provide a right to appeal?

Five moral dimensions

01 Information rights and obligations

02 Property rights and obligations

03 Accountability and control

04 System quality

05 Quality of life

[1] Figure 4.1, reproduced in the course slides, Chapter 4, p. 8. Wording and application are our own.

CASE 1 / NEW HAMPSHIRE, USA / JANUARY 2024

A cloned Biden voice called voters

WHAT HAPPENED

Robocalls using an AI-cloned voice urged voters to skip the presidential primary.

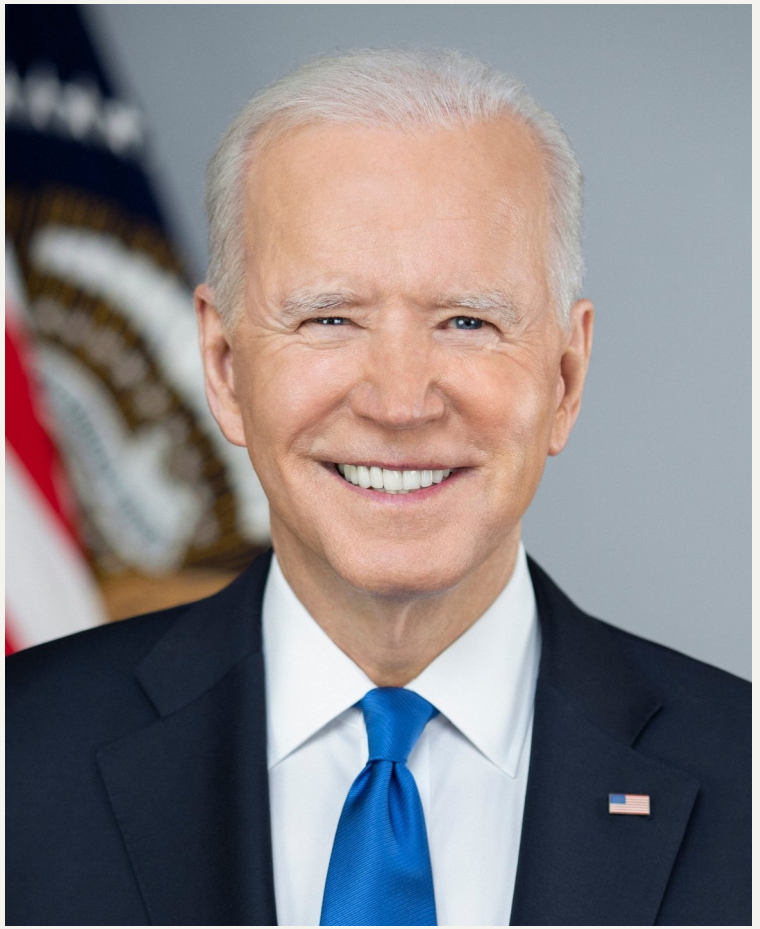
ETHICAL ISSUE

A deceptive identity undermines voters’ ability to make an informed decision.

CONSEQUENCES AND RESPONSIBILITY

Steve Kramer commissioned the campaign. The FCC imposed a $6 million administrative fine in 2024.

A jury acquitted Kramer in the separate state criminal case in June 2025. A turnout effect is not established here.



[3] FCC, 26 September 2024. [4] NHPR, 13 June 2025. Photo: Adam Schultz / White House, 2021, public domain.

CASE 2 / SLOVAKIA / SEPTEMBER 2023

Fabricated audio alleged election rigging

WHAT HAPPENED

Two days before the election, audio circulated imitating politician Michal Šimečka and journalist Monika Tódová.

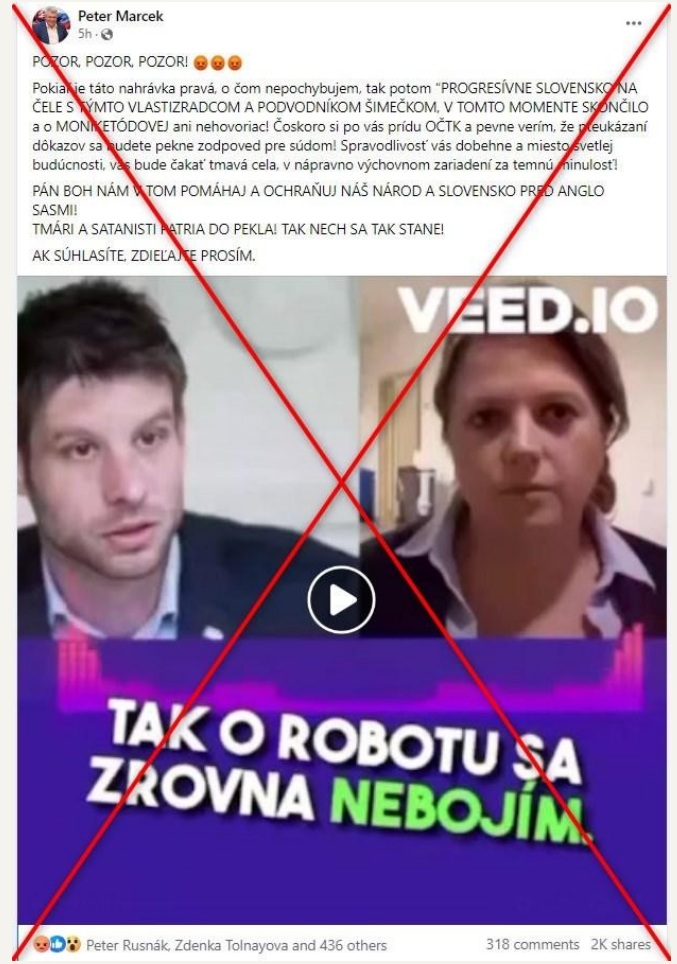
ETHICAL ISSUE

The fabricated conversation portrayed them as participants in planned election fraud.

CONSEQUENCES AND RESPONSIBILITY

Repeated sharing exposed the candidate, journalist and voters to deception. The original producer remains unidentified in the source.

AFP found signs of synthetic audio. An effect on the election result has not been established.



[5] AFP Fact Check, 28 September 2023. The image shows the false post documented and marked by AFP.

AI profiles gave propaganda a false identity

WHAT HAPPENED

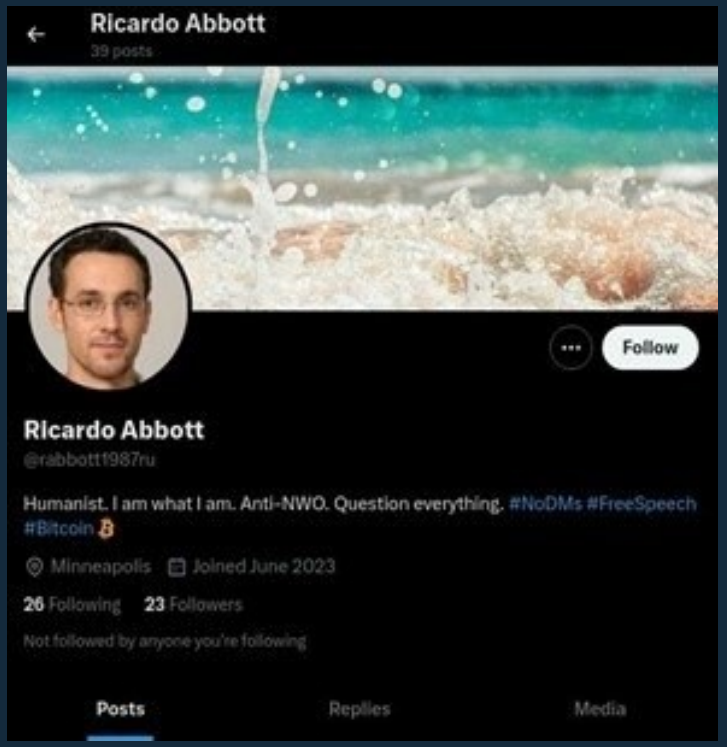
U.S. authorities identified 968 accounts. AI helped create fictitious people on X.

ETHICAL ISSUE

Covert state influence appeared to be ordinary citizens' views and activity.

CONSEQUENCES AND RESPONSIBILITY

The DOJ linked the network to RT and the FSB. Authorities seized domains, and X suspended accounts.



False identities are documented. The sources do not measure the campaign's effect on voters' attitudes.

[6] U.S. Department of Justice, 9 July 2024. [7] FBI et al., AA24-191A. Profile image from DOJ evidence.

Algorithms shape political exposure

Recommender systems rank content against selected objectives. They can change which political messages receive attention.

Study	Finding	What we can conclude
Facebook / Instagram 2020 election, published 2023	A chronological feed changed exposure, without a detectable change in polarisation.	Exposure and attitude change are different outcomes.
X 2023 experiment, published 2026	Switching the algorithm on shifted some political attitudes in a conservative direction.	Effects depend on the platform, period and outcome measured.

Political bias and factual falsity are different questions. Distribution alone does not establish an election effect.

[8] Guess et al., Science, 2023. [9] Gauthier et al., Nature, 2026. Both studies use experiments.

APPLYING FIGURE 4.1

Analysis across the model’s three levels

Case	Individual	Societal	Political and policy
Biden calls	Voter autonomy and Biden’s identity.	Risk to participation and trust in elections.	Caller identification and enforcement of election rules.
Slovak audio	The candidate’s and journalist’s reputations.	Distrust of elections and independent media.	Rapid response before elections and access to corrections.
Meliorator	Citizens’ ability to recognise the real source.	Covert foreign influence and fabricated public support.	Platform oversight and international investigation.

Shared tension: free expression and citizens’ ability to recognise manipulation.

[1] Laudon & Laudon, Figure 4.1. Our analysis draws on the case sources [3-7].

FIGURE 4.1 / ACCOUNTABILITY AND CONTROL

Accountability needs controls and appeals

Actor	Responsibility	Controls and follow-up
Creator / commissioner	Bears primary responsibility for deliberate deception.	Identify the source and preserve evidence.
Platform / telecom	Limits coordinated abuse and responds promptly.	Keep logs, explain interventions and provide appeals.
AI provider	Addresses foreseeable misuse of its tools.	Test risks and support traceability.
Public authority	Enforces rules and protects rights.	Independent oversight and access to review.

Ethical responsibility, administrative penalties and criminal guilt are distinct.

[1] Laudon & Laudon. This allocation of duties is our recommendation, informed by the cases and DSA guidance [11].

Solutions must address several stages

Response	Application to the cases	Limitation
Technical controls Origin checks	Authenticate callers. Label AI content and preserve origin information.	Sources can lie. Labels can be removed.
Organisation Election response	Shared contact point, rapid fact-checking and visible corrections.	Corrections may miss the original audience.
Platform design Bot detection	Detect bot farms. Test recommenders for abuse.	Errors can restrict legitimate debate.
Regulation Oversight / appeals	Require risk assessment, researcher access and reasoned decisions.	Oversight needs resources and due process.

Our proposals draw on [3], [7] and the European Commission’s guidance [10-11].

EU rules and freedom of expression

AI ACT, ARTICLE 50

Actors within scope must disclose deepfakes. Providers also face machine-readable marking requirements for generated content.

DIGITAL SERVICES ACT

Very large platforms must assess and mitigate systemic election risks. Oversight and researcher access support scrutiny.

Interventions should be proportionate, reasoned and open to appeal. Satire and legitimate political debate need protection.

Article 50 applies from 2 August 2026. Certain existing systems have a transition period until 2 December 2026 for technical marking.

[10] European Commission, Article 50 FAQ and Quick Facts. [11] DSA election guidelines. Summary.

OUR CONCLUSION

Overall assessment

AI makes false voices and identities easier to produce. Democratic vulnerability also depends on distribution and accountability.

REALISTIC DANISH EXAMPLE / HYPOTHETICAL

An audio clip impersonates a candidate shortly before an election. A platform temporarily limits distribution while a response team verifies its origin and gives the source an opportunity to respond.

A justified response protects informed participation and provides a way to correct mistakes.

CHOOSE A, B, C OR D / DISCUSS FOR 30 SECONDS

Multiple-choice question

A viral audio clip impersonates a candidate one day before an election. Its origin is unknown and an AI detector is uncertain. What is the best response?

A Remove every political post until the election is over.

B Verify the source, act proportionately, and provide an appeal.

C Add an AI label and leave distribution unchanged.

D Use the AI detector as the sole basis for removal.

REVEAL AFTER DISCUSSION

Correct answer: B

Verify the source, act proportionately, and provide an appeal.

WHY B?

It combines verification, proportionate action and a way to correct a mistaken decision.

A suppresses debate too broadly. C relies on a label alone. D ignores the detector’s uncertainty.

References and image credits

[1] Laudon & Laudon. Figure 4.1
Course slides: Chapter 4, p. 8. Edition not specified.

[2] Council of Europe (2018). Information disorder
IRIS 2018-1:1/6, on Wardle & Derakhshan (2017).

[3] FCC (26 September 2024). Biden robocalls
DOC-405811A1. Administrative penalty and incident.

[4] Bookman / NHPR (13 June 2025)
Kramer’s acquittal in the separate state criminal case.

[5] Barca / AFP (28 September 2023)
Fact-check of the fabricated Slovak audio recording.

[6] U.S. DOJ (9 July 2024). AI bot farm
Authorities’ evidence and attribution.

[7] FBI et al. (9 July 2024). Meliorator
Joint Cybersecurity Advisory AA24-191A.

[8] Guess et al. (2023). Feed algorithms
Science 381, 398-404. doi:10.1126/science.abp9364

[9] Gauthier et al. (2026). X’s feed algorithm
Nature 652, 416-423. doi:10.1038/s41586-026-10098-2

[10] European Commission. AI Act, Article 50
Transparency FAQ and Quick Facts on deadlines.

[11] European Commission (2024). DSA
Guidelines on systemic risks to electoral processes.

Images: David Iliff (2014), European Parliament, cropped. Adam Schultz / White House (2021), Biden, public domain.
Case images: AFP [5] and U.S. DOJ [6], source excerpts for analysis. Full sources and image links appear in the speaker notes.

Parliament photograph: CC BY-SA 3.0. creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/3.0/

Sources accessed 20 October 2026. Documented events, authorities’ attribution and our ethical assessments are distinguished.